could understand her desire to express herself through art. But to do that, she needed freedom—a distant memory now.

Lagerführer Klein blew the whistle, and the women marched in a line—Dutch, French and Italian at the front, followed by Poles and Russians bringing up the rear, guarded by an armed soldier. The line of women trickled away at each factory they passed, depending on where they were assigned to work. Across from the train station, a stone marker rose in the air on which the names of towns—Dresden and Berlin—and the distances to reach them were carved. The sky was no longer dark, and Rose would have liked to steal away from the women and find a quiet place where she could be left alone to sketch. When they reached the end of the town, they arrived at the Archimedes factory—a three-story building with large windows.

The Lagerführer pointed to a side door. “Show your pass and give the guard this card, indicating it is your first day. He will call the Meister, factory overseer, to come and collect you.” She pulled out a card from a pile in her bag. “Your shift ends at four in the afternoon.”

Rose’s knees wobbled. Ten hours. She’d never cleaned that long. What would they have her do?

“Shall we wait for you to collect us to return to the barracks?” Léa asked.

The Lagerführer shook her head. “Return to the barracks as you wish. Town shops accept ration coupons. Be back by eight. Lights out at ten.” She turned and walked away.

Rose nudged Léa. “You see, I could have brought my sketchpad.”

“Then, bring it tomorrow. Come on, let’s find out what we’ll be doing.”

The Meister was an older, burly man with a long gray mustache curled at the end. Rose wondered whether he applied wax to keep it in place because the gray hairs shimmered when the light hit them at a certain angle.

“*Bienvenue, mesdemoiselles*,” he said, startling the sisters with his ability to speak French.

“*Merci, monsieur*.” Léa smiled. “*Où avez-vous appris le français*?”

His beefy arms shot up, crossing like a railway sign as he switched to German. The sisters would soon learn he admired France and often dropped in French words, hoping it would help them understand.

Now, with his index finger, he motioned for Rose to follow and for Léa